Quickstart Guide

EMA In-Lab Protocol — Tilburg University

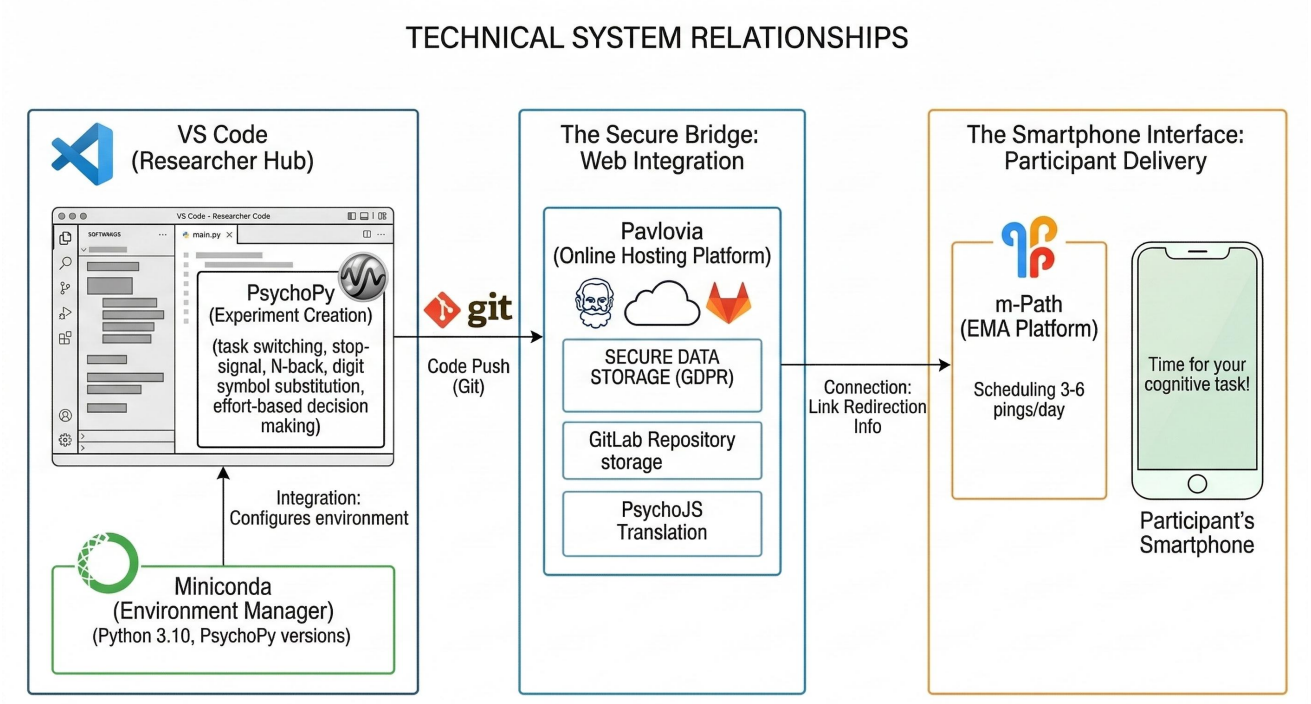
Who is this guide for? Students with little or no programming experience who need to set up and use PsychoPy-based cognitive tasks on a Windows PC. No prior coding knowledge is assumed.

How to Use This Guide

This guide is organized into two levels.

Level	Goal	Steps to complete
Level 1	Powershell and Downloads/Accounts	Sections 1 & 2
Level 2	Familiarizing with applications	Sections 3, 4, & 5

The Big Picture: How the Tools Connect



Tool	What it does
Miniconda	Installs and manages Python environments
psychopy_env	A Python 3.10 environment pre-loaded with PsychoPy and all required packages to
VS Code	Code editor where you read, edit, and run experiment scripts
PsychoPy	The Python library that actually runs cognitive tasks
Pavlovia	Hosts the web version of tasks so participants can do them on a phone
m-Path	Sends scheduled notifications to participants and links them to Pavlovia

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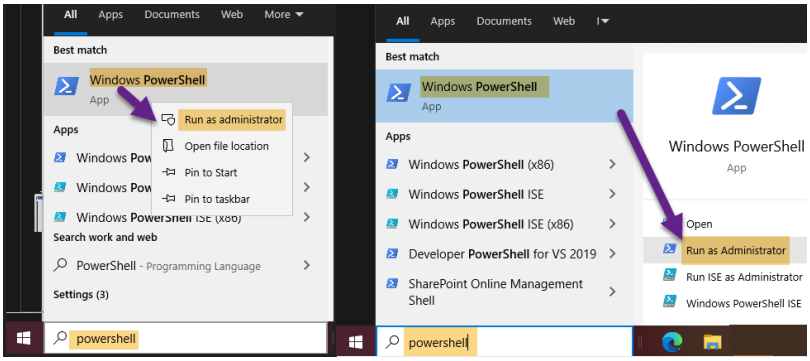
Section 1 — Enable Script Execution (Windows only)

Powershell is a **a command-line shell and scripting platform for automation and systems management**. In other words, it can controll your computer similar to what we do when tuning our settings in our smartphones. Windows blocks scripts by default. You must change this setting once before anything else will work. This is the first line of code you going to run!

1. Press **Win**, type **Powershell**, right-click it, and choose **Run as Administrator**



2. **Paste** the following **command** and press **Enter**:

   Set-ExecutionPolicy -ExecutionPolicy RemoteSigned -Scope CurrentUser

3. Type Y and press Enter if prompted to confirm.

4. Close PowerShell.

Why? Without this change, Conda and many other tools will silently fail to activate environments or run scripts on Windows.

Section 2 — Downloads Checklist

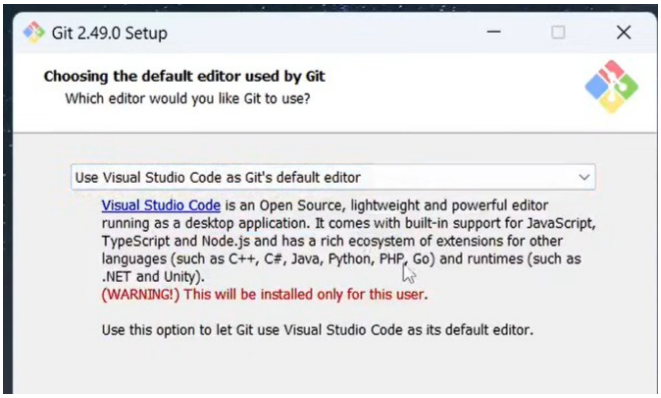
Download and install these applications in order to get your computer ready for programming.

2a. Required for all levels

#	What	Where to get it	Notes
1	**VS Code**	Download Visual Studio Code - Mac, Linux, Windows	Choose the Windows installer or MacOs depending on your PC
2	**Miniconda**	Download Anaconda Distribution Anaconda	Scroll to the bottom to find miniconda installer and follow the installation process
3	**psychopy_env.yml**	github.com/rcarrioncanonico/Momentary-Assesment-Tools	Click **Raw**, then Ctrl+S to save as psychopy_env.yml
4	**Git**	Git - Install	Necessary to Push code to Pavlovia

Important:

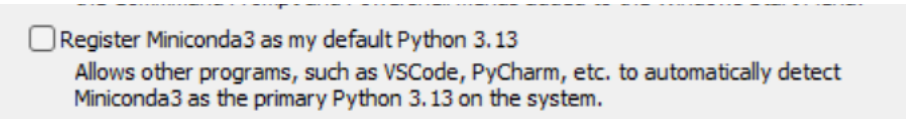
During Git Installation there will be a window that will ask you to choose a default editor, be sure to select Visual Studio Code just like in this image:



This is the only modification you have to do during Git installation.

Important:

During Miniconda Installation be sure to leave this box unchecked like in this image:



2b. Necessary Accounts

#	What	Where to get it	Notes
5	**Github**	GitHub	Needed to sync with VS-Code and to access AI Copilot for easy coding
6	**Pavlovia account**	pavlovia.org	Free for researchers
7	**m-Path account**	m-path.io	Coordinate with your supervisor

2c. Optional additional program:

#	What	Where to get it	Notes
8	**PsychoPy Standalone**	psychopy.org/download.html	In-case you are curious how PsychoPy looks like

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Section 3 — Miniconda Use

Once Miniconda is intalled you will have a new application called **Anaconda Prompt** which looks like this:

To build the psychopy_env workspace that we need for all scripts to run PsychoPy tasks we need to:

1. Press Win, type **Anaconda Prompt**, and open it (similar to **section 1**).

2. **Skip this step if your psychopy_env.yml is in the Downloads folder**. To change where **Anaconda Prompt** searches for the folder containing the saved psychopy_env.yml . Copy and paste the code below:

cd %USERPROFILE%

3. Create the PsychoPy environment by running this code:

conda env create -f psychopy_env.yml

4. This downloads and installs all required packages. It may take 5–15 minutes.

5. To confirm it succeeded — you should see a psychopy_env folder here:

C:\Users<YourName>\miniconda3\envs\psychopy_env

6.) You can also check by running this code in **Anaconda Prompt**:

conda env list

psychopy_env should appear in the list.

It will appear something like this:

```
(base) C:\Users\rodri>conda env list

# conda environments:
#
# * -> active
# + -> frozen
base                  *  C:\Users\rodri\miniconda3
neural_data_science      C:\Users\rodri\miniconda3\envs\neural_data_science
psychopy_env             C:\Users\rodri\miniconda3\envs\psychopy_env
base                  *  C:\Users\rodri\miniconda3
psychopy_env             C:\Users\rodri\miniconda3\envs\psychopy_env


(base) C:\Users\rodri>
```

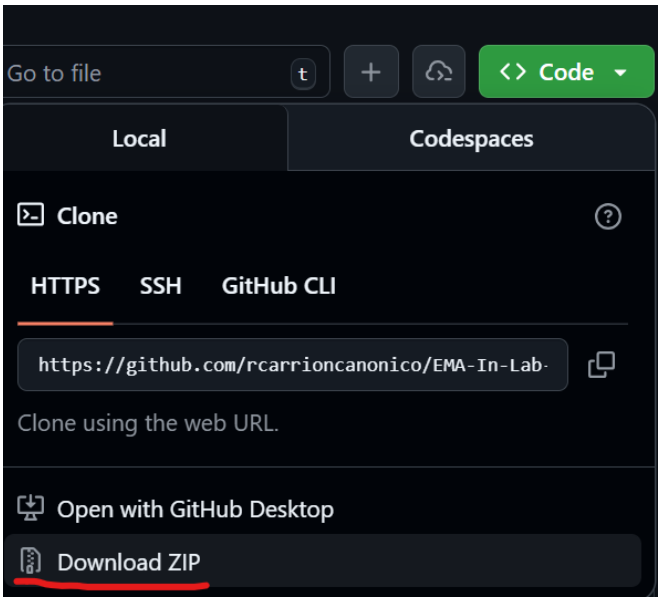
Section 4: GitHub Familiarization

Like anything new, GitHub looks scary and contains a lot of new terminology which we are not use to. Terms like "**Repositories**", "**Commit**", "**Pull Requests**" and "**Branch**" are common terms in the GitHub community

You have access to this document through the public *repository* known as EMA-In-Lab-Protocol (Link). A *repository* is nothing more than a *big folder* which was uploaded to the cloud in GitHub. It contains different files such as this PDF document, other file types such as jupyter notebook files (.ipynb), python files (.py) and can also contain even more folders inside of it.

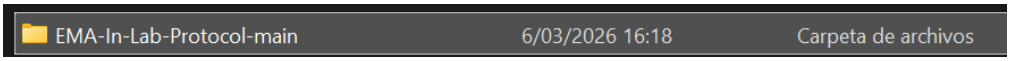
As you can see the EMA-In-Lab-Protocol has a lot of different files in it. This Quick Guide PDF was just one of those files inside that repository. In order to use this protocol we will want to clone (download) the whole repository into your computer.

There are different ways of saving (cloning) a repository into your computer. The simplest way of doing that is to go to the "**Green Box** that has "**Code** written on it, **click** on it and **click Download Zip**



Once the Zip file is download. You will find it in your files in "Downloads", hover the cursor on the zip file, *right click* and then click on *extract everything* and confirm extraction.

A new folder with the same name of the zip file will be created, be sure to remember where it is located, which would be in the Downloads folder if you don´t decide to change its location.



Recommended- Obtain Copilot Pro

Coding has never been easier with the help of AI and students and teachers can get Copilot Pro for free for 2 years. Be sure to link your account to the GitHub Education benefits following the instructions of this Link.

For now that is all you have to do in GitHub, but if you wish to know more about it, I recommend this quick 10 minute video to know more about GitHub. How To Use GitHub For Beginners - YouTube

Section 5 — VS Code Familiarization

5a. User Interface

Just like GitHUb, VS-Code can be a little bit confusing and overwhelming as soon as you start it up, don´t worry the user-interface is pretty friendly once you get use to it. Since it is better to visualize someone using VS-Code rather than in text, I recommend you to watch the first 7 minutes of this video which explains the very initial steps of installing and opening VS-Code. These 7 minutes also explains the "Explorer" part of the "Activity Bar" of VS-Code. Be sure to have VS-Code open along these videos so you can familiarize yourself with the application.

[VS Code for Absolute Beginners]

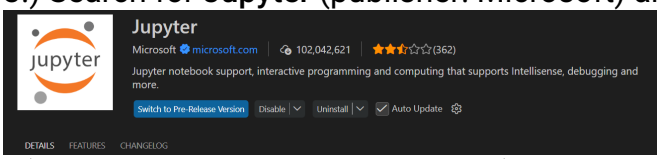
Another recommended video is the following, in which the first 12 minutes are enough for you to know the other functions such as extensions and the use of Copilot AI.

[Learn Visual Studio Code in 15 minutes: 2026 Official Beginner Tutorial - YouTube]

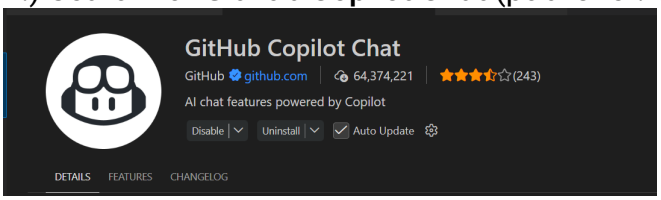
5b. Installing Necessary Extension and Linking GitHub.

As this tutorial works within the VS-Code enviroment, we are going to need to install some extensions to run other types of files such as Jupyter Notebook files known to finish in .ipynb.

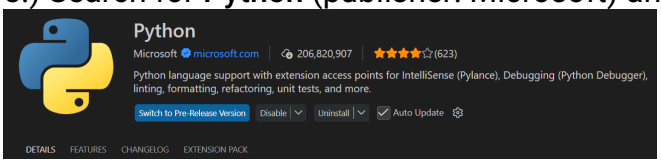
1. 1.) Open VS Code.
2. 2.) Click the **Extensions** icon in the left sidebar (it looks like four squares, or press Ctrl+Shift+X).
3. 3.) Search for **Jupyter** (publisher: Microsoft) and click **Install**.



4. 4.) Search for **GitHub Copilot Chat** (publisher: GitHub) and click **Install**



5. 5.) Search for **Python** (publisher: Microsoft) and click **Install**

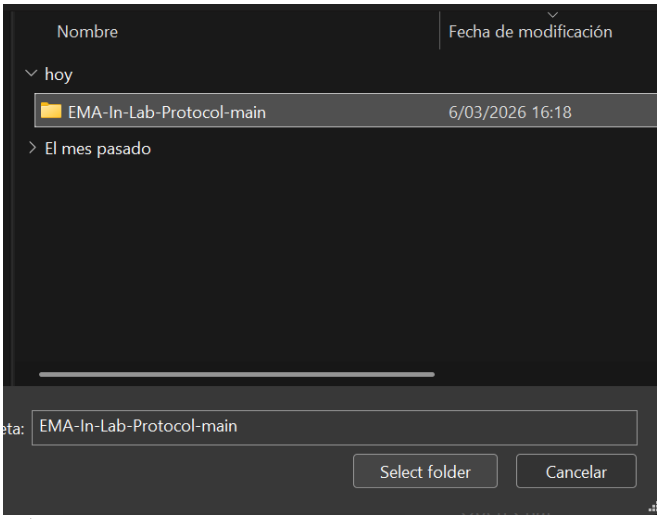


On the "Activity Bar" on the left hand sight of VS-Code you will see an Icon with a cat on it, click on it and sign in with your Github account in order to sync VS-Code with Github and be able to

use all of the AI pro tools. If you wish to know more about how GitHub works inside VS-Code you can check out this link: [Working with GitHub in VS Code]

5c. Open the Protocol Folder

1. 1.) In VS Code, go to **File --> Open Folder**. You can find "**File**" on the top-left corner of VS-Code
2. 2.) Navigate to Downloads Folder
3. 3.) **Select** the folder known as EMA-In-Lab-Protocol-main (the one we downloaded and extracted in **Section 4**.



4. 4.) Once selected, you will see all of the files of the repository in the "Explorer" icon of the "Activity Bar" which is the "paper looking" icon on the left hand side of VS-Code.

Congratulations! you are free to explore the files of the repository inside VS-Code. From now on this tutorial will take place inside VS-Code. All the files needed to continue were already open during section **5c**. Your next step is to open Jupyter_Starter file inside VS-Code.